

SHADOWS OVER SABRES BLUFF

A DROP IN THIEVES GUILD &
CREATION TOOLKIT

MATT BELCHER

Includes stat blocks compatible with
Old school D&D, D20 System and 5E

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INTRODUCTION TO SABRES BLUFF

A Personal Note from the Author

Thieves and rogues have always been at the heart of fantasy roleplaying, weaving their way through tales of intrigue, deception, and daring exploits. They are the ones who slip through the shadows, uncover whispered secrets, and tip the balance of power with a flick of the wrist or the lift of a coin purse. From the earliest days of tabletop roleplaying, they have stood as both scoundrels and heroes, straddling the line between criminal and champion.

When I set out to write *Shadows Over Sabres Bluff: The Thieves' Codex*, I wanted to create a comprehensive guide not just for playing rogues but for breathing life into an entire underworld—one rich with opportunity, peril, and endless adventure hooks. Sabres Bluff, as a setting, has always been a place of layered intrigue, where the streets themselves seem to whisper conspiracies, and where every alleyway might hold a new contact, rival, or opportunity for wealth. This book is designed to be more than just a resource—it is an invitation to immerse yourself in a world where cunning is as valuable as steel, and where those who master the art of deception can shape the fate of nations.

For years, I have been drawn to iconic rogue characters, from the silver-tongued swindlers of classic literature to the master thieves of cinematic heists. Their stories are ones of wit, charm, and calculated risk—qualities that make for compelling gameplay and memorable campaigns. Whether you wish to play a cunning mastermind orchestrating grand heists, a shadowy cutpurse navigating a city's criminal underbelly, or a charismatic scoundrel forging alliances and deceiving enemies, this book provides the tools to craft such stories with depth and authenticity.

Enter the Shadows: The Underworld of Sabres Bluff

Sabres Bluff is not just a city; it is an ecosystem of crime, power, and opportunity. At its heart lie the Thieves' Guilds—structured organizations that blend necessity with ambition, enforcing their own laws in the shadows while bending the city's rulers to their will. Some thieves operate within these guilds, bound by codes of loyalty and discipline, while others chart their own path, leveraging informants and secret safehouses to remain one step ahead of the city watch.

Yet, thievery in Sabres Bluff is not merely about picking locks and cutting purses. It is about navigating the ever-shifting currents of the underworld, forming tenuous alliances, and outwitting both rivals and authorities. The city itself breathes with opportunity—its ports, merchant houses, and noble estates are all potential marks for the daring, while the Ratways, Gilded Quarter, and Smugglers' Docks each offer their own perils and rewards.

In this book, you will find the framework to explore all aspects of this world, from the intricacies of guild life to the strategies behind high-stakes heists. Whether you are a Game Master seeking to weave an intricate web of underworld intrigue or a player looking to bring a truly legendary rogue to life, *The Thieves' Codex* provides everything you need to create a campaign where the shadows hold as much adventure as the grandest battlefields.

An Invitation to GMs and Players

This book is for those who revel in the art of the rogue—both Game Masters and players alike. It is for those who wish to build living, breathing underworlds within their campaigns, filled with rival factions, shifting allegiances, and plots waiting to be unravelled. It is for those who want to run thrilling heists, elaborate cons, and daring escapes from the city watch.

Game Masters will find a wealth of resources for integrating thieves' guilds into their settings, from detailed guild structures to ready-made adventure hooks.

Rogues are more than just a class in a game; they are the embodiment of adaptability and wit, of careful planning and bold execution. In their hands, a simple heist can change the course of history, and a whispered secret can topple a kingdom. If you have ever wanted to dive into a world where every decision is a gamble & every success a triumph of cunning, *Shadows Over Sabres Bluff* is your guide to mastering the art of the rogue.



Welcome to the shadows. May your steps be silent, your plans flawless, and your coin purses ever full.

WHAT THIS BOOK IS ABOUT

The World of Thieves' Guilds and Rogues

At its core, *Shadows Over Sabres Bluff: The Thieves' Codex* is a book about thieves' guilds and the rogues who call them home. It is about creating immersive campaigns where the criminal underworld is more than a backdrop—it is a living, breathing entity filled with ambition, treachery, and opportunity.

This book provides a comprehensive guide for Game Masters and players alike to build, integrate, and run thieves' guilds as dynamic elements of their campaigns. Whether you seek to craft a world-spanning organization of cunning masterminds or a loose band of cutthroats operating in the back alleys of a single city, this codex gives you the tools to bring them to life.

Exploring the Underworld: The Focus of This Book

This book delves deep into the mechanics and roleplaying elements of guild life, from their structure and traditions to the power struggles that shape them. The pages herein explore:

- The Structure of Thieves' Guilds: Hierarchies, roles, recruitment, and internal politics.
- The Lives of Thieves and Rogues: How thieves fit into their guilds and the broader world.
- Guild Conflicts and Politics: Power struggles, rivalries, and the ever-present risk of betrayal.
- Running Immersive Thief Campaigns: How to craft compelling stories around heists, smuggling, and clandestine dealings.

Whether your campaign features a single thieves' guild or an entire web of criminal factions vying for control, this book provides the framework to make the underworld engaging and fun.

The Key Themes of Thief-Focused Campaigns

A well-crafted thieves' guild campaign is about more than stealing—it's about navigating a world of danger and intrigue where every decision can shift the balance of power. Some of the core themes explored in this book include:

- Guild Politics: Power is always contested. Guild leaders must balance loyalty, ambition, and treachery.
- Moral Ambiguity: Few rogues are purely good or evil. Every thief must decide where their personal code begins and ends.
- Clandestine Operations: Heists, espionage, and the shadowy world of underworld dealings are at the heart of every great thief's guild.
- Reputation and Legacy: In the criminal world, a thief's reputation is their greatest asset—or their greatest weakness.

By embracing these themes, a Game Master can create a world where players' actions carry lasting consequences, and where every score, betrayal, and whispered secret matters.

Who This Book Is For

This book is primarily designed for Game Masters who want to incorporate thieves' guilds into their campaigns as more than simple adversaries or background elements. It offers detailed tools for creating engaging guilds, designing high-stakes heists, and weaving intrigue into a setting.

However, it is also valuable for:

- Players who wish to create rogues that feel deeply tied to the world, with guild connections, rivalries, and personal ambitions.
- Authors seeking to craft realistic and engaging fantasy settings where thieves' guilds and organized crime play a significant role.

Running Thief-Centric Campaigns

A great thief-focused campaign requires more than just pickpocket rolls and stealth checks—it is about crafting stories where every action carries weight. By using the tools in this book, Game Masters can create a world where thieves' guilds are not just set pieces, but the very fabric of the campaign's intrigue.

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK: SHADOWS OVER SABRES BLUFF

This book is your resource for integrating a vibrant underworld into your campaign. Whether you need a ready-to-use thieves' guild with fully developed structures, plots, and NPCs, or you want to craft your own criminal organization from scratch, the following text offers the tools and inspiration you need.

Use the table of contents to quickly jump to the section that best fits your current needs—whether it's for a one-off heist, a recurring faction, or a full-blown underworld campaign.

Navigating the Book

The Book is divided into four main sections, each designed for different levels of detail and customization:

Section A – The Realm & the Underworld: Explore the broader setting of Sabres Bluff with chapters on the Cities of Sabres Bluff, the Guilds of the Underworld, and the Art of Survival. This section sets the stage by describing the environment, the opportunities, and the dangers lurking in every alley.

Section B – A Drop-In Guild: A fully detailed thieves' guild—the Street Shadows. With chapters covering everything from its history, internal structure, legal and operational tactics, to challenges and risks, this section is perfect if you want an established criminal faction ready for immediate use in your campaign.

Section C – Creating Thief Guilds: For a more hands-on approach, this section provides a step-by-step guide and customizable templates for designing your own guild. It covers background, organization, character profiles, operations, and major activities, allowing you to tailor a guild to your campaign's unique flavour.

Section D – Thieves & Rogues in Sabres Bluff: Enrich your campaign with detailed insights into the culture of crime, the underworld's ecosystem, and the interplay between official law and street justice. This section supplies narrative hooks and background flavour to deepen the roleplaying experience.

Appendix – Random Tables: Use these quick-reference tables for generating heist twists, NPC backstories, essential rogue gear, and even secret code phrases. They're designed for rapid lookup to keep gameplay fast and engaging.

Using the Content

Drop-In Guild: If you need a quick faction, start with Section B. The Street Shadows are a complete, ready-to-play guild with pre-made plots, key figures, and operational details. Simply insert them into your campaign, adjust names or locations as needed, and let the adventure unfold.

Adapting Sample Material: The detailed descriptions, narrative hooks, and roll tables throughout Sections A, C, and D are designed for customization. Swap out names, tweak settings, or modify internal conflicts to fit your world perfectly. Use the random tables in the Appendix for spontaneous twists or fresh inspiration during sessions.

Building Your Own Guild: Section C offers a comprehensive framework for creating a unique thieves' guild. Follow the step-by-step guides and templates to define your guild's background, structure, and key characters. This modular approach lets you build an organization that can evolve with your campaign.

By combining ready-made elements with flexible creation tools and dynamic random generators, Shadows Over Sabres Bluff empowers you to craft a living, breathing criminal underworld. Use the clear chapter headings to navigate to the content you need and adapt the material freely to enrich your campaign with endless adventure possibilities.



SECTION A

THE REALM & THE UNDERWORLD

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The realm of Sabres Bluff is not merely a kingdom, a city, or a collection of streets—it is a living, breathing entity, a creature whose very bones are cobblestone and whose veins run thick with shadowed intrigue. Every alleyway hums with whispered secrets, every towering spire conceals plots as grand as the architecture that supports it. It is a land where crime is not just committed in darkness but woven seamlessly into the fabric of daily existence, hidden beneath the gilded veneer of high society.

The Capital: Sabres Bluff City: The city of Sabres Bluff, the realm's heart, beats with the rhythm of commerce, diplomacy, and deception. Ruled by Lady Yolande Seabreeze, the city thrives as a centre of trade, boasting a population of 32,000 where humans mingle with elves, dwarves, halflings, and half-elves, each adding to the tapestry of its culture and corruption. Grand estates line the higher tiers of the city, places of ostentation where nobles cloak their illicit dealings beneath the silken drapes of civility. Here, the well-dressed trade secrets as easily as they exchange coin.

But beneath this façade of respectability lies a network of guilds, smugglers, and cutpurses who carve out their own domain in the city's shadowed corners. The docks teem with contraband, illicit goods slipping through the hands of smugglers before reaching the bustling Grand Market, where merchants unknowingly fence stolen wares. The nobility, meanwhile, turn a blind eye, content in their own web of corruption so long as their power remains unchallenged.

Architecture and Culture: The cityscape of Sabres Bluff is a blend of old-world grandeur and grim practicality. Narrow winding streets, secretive courtyards, and grandiose manors provide ample refuge for those who deal in whispers. The Shattered Ward is a prime example—a place where the forgotten and forsaken gather, where every tavern serves as both sanctuary and snare. The Gilded Quarter, by contrast, is a haven for the privileged, a place of splendour where pickpockets prowl beneath lamplight, their nimble fingers relieving distracted merchants of their gold.

Politics in Sabres Bluff is a game of masks, where crime and governance are often intertwined. Corrupt magistrates, greedy merchants, and rogue nobles use underground networks to settle disputes far from the prying eyes of commoners. The ruling class maintains a delicate balance, allowing crime to flourish so long as it remains unseen and unspoken. It is said that the true rulers of Sabres Bluff are not the nobles, but those who thrive in its underbelly—the thieves, spies, and assassins who pull the strings from the shadows.

Crime and the Unseen Hand: In Sabres Bluff, crime is not an aberration but a silent partner to civilization. The city guard is often either complicit or outmatched, struggling to suppress the burgeoning underworld. The Street Shadows, the city's premier thieves' guild, ensures that crime remains well-organized, maintaining control over heists, smuggling rings, and espionage. Their agents lurk in the darkened corridors of the Blackened Spire, their headquarters hidden among the winding streets.

While commoners live their lives oblivious to the grand game played around them, crime touches every aspect of existence. The city's port serves as a gateway for black-market trade, while the Ratways, a labyrinthine network of tunnels and slums, offer refuge to outcasts and fugitives. From the market squares, where swindlers practice their art of deception, to the noble estates, where betrayal is often more valuable than gold, crime is both a livelihood and a necessity.

The realm of Sabres Bluff is a city of secrets, a world where every darkened doorway leads to danger, and every whispered conversation could seal one's fate. It is a place where opportunity and peril walk hand in hand, where the cunning may rise, and the careless may fall, and where those who know how to navigate its treacherous streets may find fortune—not in the light, but in the shadows over Sabres Bluff.

CHAPTER 1A: THE CITIES OF SABRES BLUFF

The realm of Sabres Bluff is a land of opportunity for those who walk the shadowed path. Each of its cities and towns offers a distinct environment for rogues, con artists, and master thieves to ply their trade. Whether one seeks to swindle a noble, smuggle contraband, or carve a name in the underworld, each locale presents unique challenges and rewards.

SABRES BLUFF – THE TOWERING CAPITAL OF SHADOWS

Population: 32,000

Crime Allegiances: The Street Shadows, The Black Fog, The Silent Knife

Underworld Specialty: Organized heists, smuggling, noble intrigue

The capital is the crown jewel of the realm, a city where wealth and vice go hand in hand. Its streets are a tapestry of opulence and decay, where the noble elite conduct backroom deals while assassins lurk in the rafters above.

Criminal Traditions & Underworld Factions

The Street Shadows – The most powerful thieves' guild, controlling smuggling, espionage, and major heists. Their members operate from the Blackened Spire, a fortress of shadows where plans for the city's greatest robberies are hatched.

The Black Fog – A network of assassins and spies who sell information and silence for a price. Their agents move unseen through the city's noble quarters.

The Silver Syndicate – A cartel of counterfeiters and financial manipulators, who rig the economy by flooding the market with fake coin and forged contracts.

The Tideborn – A guild of smugglers and black-market dealers. Their hidden docks beneath the city allow for discreet operations. This is not their Main Base of Operations.

Challenges & Opportunities

The Grand Heist: The noble estates are ripe for burglary, but enchanted locks and private guards pose major risks.

The Informant's Web: Information is currency, and those who can trade secrets can rise in the ranks.

The Docks' Smuggling Rings: Contraband flows through the capital's port—if one can outmanoeuvre both The Street Shadows and the city watch.

SEABREEZE – THE SMUGGLER'S PARADISE

Population: 13,500

Crime Allegiances: The Tideborn, The Dock Rats, The Grey Fangs

Underworld Specialty: Smuggling, piracy, counterfeit goods

Seabreeze is a bustling coastal city, where every warehouse conceals illicit cargo and every ship's captain has a hidden agenda. The city's underground thrives under the watchful eyes of merchants, corrupt harbourmasters, and outlaw captains.

Criminal Traditions & Underworld Factions

The Tideborn – A guild of smugglers and black-market dealers, ensuring that stolen goods from across the realm find their way into the right hands. Their hidden docks beneath the city allow for discreet operations.

The Dock Rats – A gang of cutthroats who rule the city's slums. They specialize in protection rackets, press-ganging desperate sailors, and ambushing trade shipments.

The Grey Fangs – A feared band of sea raiders and pirate captains who have a loose alliance with Seabreeze's criminals, operating under a code of honour among thieves.

Challenges & Opportunities

Shipboard Heists: Docked merchant vessels are treasure troves for a bold rogue.

Contraband Running: Smuggling rare goods (or people) past the city watch is lucrative—if one is fast enough.

The Pirate's Gambit: A successful thief might earn a place on a notorious pirate crew, living beyond the reach of the law.

BARDSONG – THE CITY OF ARTISTS AND TRICKSTERS

Population: 12,000

Crime Allegiances: The Masquerade, The Painted Hands, The Whispered Song

Underworld Specialty: Confidence tricks, forgeries, performance-based swindles

Bardsong is a city of performance and deception, where charlatans, illusionists, and gamblers flourish. Its thieves do not merely pick pockets—they weave elaborate cons and stage grand illusions to separate fools from their wealth.

Criminal Traditions & Underworld Factions

The Masquerade – A network of con artists, disguise masters, and illusionists who pull off grand schemes, from fake royal inheritances to rigged gambling rings.

The Painted Hands – A thieves' guild that specializes in art forgeries and enchanted **counterfeit items**, ensuring that nobles spend fortunes on worthless trinkets.

The Whispered Song – A secretive organization of spies and blackmailers, who **trade in secrets** instead of coin.

Challenges & Opportunities

The Grand Con: Posing as a noble, selling a false masterpiece, or outwitting a rival charlatan can make one rich overnight.

Gambling Rings: The city is filled with illegal betting houses, where a **rogue** with sharp dice or sleight of hand can earn a fortune—or lose everything.

The Blackmail Trade: Knowledge is power in Bardsong, and those who **uncover** the city's darkest secrets can hold lords and guildmasters in their grip.

ROWANSTONE – THE MERCANTILE HEART OF THE REALM

Population: 12,500

Crime Allegiances: The Coinblades, The Midnight Collectors, The Silver Syndicate

Underworld Specialty: Trade fraud, extortion, **high-stakes heists**

Rowanstone is the wealthiest city outside of the capital, a place where merchants rise and fall on the whims of trade. However, behind the **respectable storefronts**, the criminal underworld dictates who profits and who is ruined.

Criminal Traditions & Underworld Factions

The Coinblades – A mercenary guild that acts as **debt collectors** and enforcers, ensuring that those who fail to pay their **debts** disappear without a trace.

The Midnight Collectors – A **syndicate** of elite burglars who break into vaults, warehouses, and **merchant estates** to **redistribute wealth**—into their own pockets.

The Silent Knife – A brutal gang of street enforcers who control the slums, acting as hired muscle for criminals and merchants alike.

Challenges & Opportunities

The Merchant's Vault: Breaking into **heavily guarded warehouses** is dangerous, but the rewards are immense.

Forgery and Deception: Creating **false merchant seals** or **fraudulent trade contracts** can topple **entire businesses** overnight.

Extortion and Debt Collection: Those with the right leverage can demand **protection money** or **manipulate the trade routes** to their advantage.

The Realm of Rogues Awaits

Across Sabres Bluff, crime is more than an act—it is an institution, a way of life, and a path to power. Each city offers its own unique playground for those willing to seize opportunity in the shadows. Whether stealing from nobles, smuggling goods past the watch, or weaving elaborate deceptions, the realm belongs to those bold enough to take it.

THE NOTABLE DISTRICTS OF SABRES BLUFF

In Sabres Bluff, the divide between opulence and ruin is never far. The city is a realm of contrasts, where the gilded halls of the rich are mere steps from the rotting underbelly of crime and despair. These districts—each one distinct—form the backbone of the city's vibrant yet dangerous life.

THE GILDED QUARTER – A HAVEN FOR NOBLES AND THIEVES ALIKE

Location: Centre of the city, surrounding the Citadel of Stars

Reputation: Wealth, politics, intrigue, and corruption

Famous Landmarks: The Golden Crescent (exclusive noble club), The Hall of Echoing Shadows (theatre of espionage)

Overview: The Gilded Quarter is the very heart of wealth and power in Sabres Bluff. Massive mansions and towering marble estates line the district's cobblestone streets, home to the city's noble families and merchant princes. The air here is thick with the scent of luxury—silk, perfume, and freshly baked bread. Yet beneath the surface of this glittering paradise lies a game of intrigue as dangerous as it is treacherous. Here, nobles vie for control, assassins are hired with whispered promises, and alliances are as fragile as glass.

Criminal Presence and Secrets

Thieves' Game: Despite its apparent respectability, the Gilded Quarter is home to the most influential criminals. The rich may walk the streets in gilded attire, but it is the underworld that has shaped their power. Many of the city's most powerful thieves' guilds have their roots in this district, hidden beneath layers of patronage and political favour. The Street Shadows, for instance, maintains a quiet presence, offering protection in exchange for the privilege of fencing stolen goods or orchestrating discreet heists.

The Golden Crescent: This exclusive noble club is a front for the high-level dealings between nobles, spies, and rogue merchants. Rumours say that some members are deeply entwined with criminal syndicates.

The Hall of Echoing Shadows: An infamous theatre of espionage, this venue is where spies and informants meet in the dead of night. What begins as a night of performance often ends with secrets slipping into the hands of those who can afford them.

Whispers and Rumours

- "The city's wealthiest families aren't as pure as they seem. Some of the nobility are just well-dressed thieves running their own schemes."
- "Lord Darrin Windcroft owes half his fortune to the Silver Syndicate. They say his newest estate was bought with dirty money, but no one dares to speak of it aloud."
- "The Whispered Song, the guild of spies, listens to every noble's secret. They know which of your sons will inherit what, and when the next betrayal is to occur."



THE RATWAYS – THE LAWLESS SPRAWL BENEATH THE CITY

Location: Beneath the streets of Sabres Bluff, stretching through the undercity

Reputation: Lawlessness, crime, refuge for the lost

Famous Landmarks: The King's Vein (black market hub), The Graveyard of Lost Souls (hidden gang hideout)

Overview: Beneath the gleaming streets of Sabres Bluff lies a network of tunnels and passageways known as the Ratways. This district is a lawless sprawl of slums, hovels, and hidden safe houses, where the desperate and dangerous live and die by their wits. Thieves, refugees, and criminals of every stripe find sanctuary here, far from the watchful eyes of the city guard. To outsiders, the Ratways are a labyrinth of decay and danger, but to those who know its secrets, it's a place of opportunity—albeit a very deadly one.

Criminal Presence and Secrets

Black Market Hub: The King's Vein, a black market located within the Ratways, is the heart of the undercity's illicit trade. Here, one can buy anything—from weapons and smuggled goods to stolen magical artifacts. The market thrives under the protection of various gangs who run it with ruthless efficiency.

Street-Level Gangs: The Dock Rats dominate the Ratways, a violent gang that runs protection rackets, smuggles contraband, and extorts merchants. No one dares to cross them unless they have a death wish.

The Graveyard of Lost Souls: Hidden beneath the Graveyard of Lost Souls, a derelict section of the city, lies a hidden network of safe houses. Here, fugitives, runaways, and criminals on the run disappear from the city's watchful gaze. The network is managed by a shadowy figure known as The Ghost, who arranges for escape routes and safe passage for those who can pay.

Whispers and Rumours

- "Everyone says the Ghost never shows their face. They run the safe houses, but no one knows who they really are. Some say they were once a noble, others claim they're a rogue mage with an agenda of their own."
- "Those who fall behind in the Ratways have a habit of disappearing. The Dock Rats don't take kindly to weaklings."
- "There's a rumour that the Graveyard of Lost Souls leads to a hidden treasure buried deep beneath the city, but anyone who looks for it never comes back."

